

See also: The Ten Commandments and Mosaic law 20–23 ■ The *Arthashastra* and the *Manusmriti* 35 ■ The origins of canon law 42–47 ■ The Koran 54–57

The six seder (orders) of the Mishnah



Zeraim (Seeds)

Prayers, blessings, and the Torah's agricultural laws

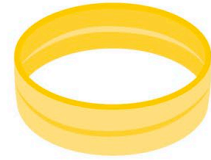
11 tractates



Moed (Festivals)

The Sabbath, Passover, and other festivals

12 tractates



Nashim (Women)

Rules on marriage, divorce, and vows

7 tractates



Nezikim (Damages)

Courts, civil and criminal law, and sayings of the Fathers

10 tractates



Kodashim (Holy things)

Temple worship, sacrifices, and dietary laws

11 tractates



Tohorot (Purities)

Ritual purity

12 tractates

Sadducees, aristocratic priests who believed only in the written law outlined in the Torah of Moses. Pharisees, on the other hand, believed in a stricter observance of Jewish law than the Sadducees. They argued that purity laws applied not only to priests, but to the daily lives of all Jewish people.

The Pharisees derived their beliefs from an oral tradition that had accrued over time. In the words of Romano-Jewish historian Josephus, "The Pharisees have delivered to the people a great many observances by succession from their fathers which are not written in the law of Moses; and for that reason it is that the Sadducees reject them." One of the Pharisees' innovations was a belief that, at the end of time, God would resurrect

the dead, punish the wicked, and reward the just. The Sadducees rejected this idea of an afterlife.

In 70 CE, following a Jewish rebellion, the Romans besieged and captured Jerusalem and razed the Temple to the ground. The Sadducees disappeared from history. The loss of the Temple was a catastrophe for Jews—in the ancient world, it was inconceivable to imagine a religion without a temple, and Jerusalem's Temple was the only place on Earth where Jews could offer sacrifices to atone for sin.

Preserving Judaism

It was largely thanks to Rabbi Yochanan ben Zakkai, a Jewish scholar, that Judaism was able to continue without a temple. He persuaded the Romans to let him

reestablish the Sanhedrin, the Jewish high council, in Yavne. Citing Hosea 6:6 in the Torah ("I desired mercy, not sacrifice"), Zakkai convinced the Sanhedrin that animal sacrifice (the preserve of temple worship) could be replaced by prayer, study of the law, and benevolence. This was justified in the Talmud with a saying of God to King David: "A single day in which you sit and engage in Torah is preferable to the thousand burnt offerings that your son Solomon will offer before Me on the altar."

After a second Jewish rebellion in 132–136 CE, Emperor Hadrian expelled all Jews from Jerusalem, which was rebuilt as a Roman city. To preserve Judaism, rabbis compiled a code of laws written in Hebrew called the Mishnah »